

A FIELD GUIDE FOR SOLO BUILDERS

The Solo Builder's Playbook

How to start a business, build with AI, and actually follow through.

everything i wish someone handed me before i wasted years figuring it out.

Reuben Dorje · @reubendorje

reubendorje.com

What is in here

00	Start here
01	The foundation
02	How to build with AI
03	The toolkit
04	The body
05	Your first 30 days
—	This is just the start

**everything i wish someone handed me before
i wasted years figuring it out.**

READ THIS FIRST

Start here

I spent years chasing my tail. Close to 20 different businesses before any of it actually worked, and most of them failed. Not because the ideas were bad, but because I kept quitting right before they would have turned, and because I had no real idea what I was doing.

This is the guide I wish someone had handed me at the start. No fluff, no theory, no motivational filler. Just the things that actually moved the needle once I worked them out the hard way.

It's for anyone who wants to build something of their own. Start a business, build an app, get your health and your head right, and actually follow through this time. You don't need a degree, funding, a team, or anyone's permission. You need a bit of direction and the willingness to stick around longer than everyone else.

Here's everything I know so far. Take what's useful, ignore what isn't, and go build.

**you dont need permission. you need
direction, and the willingness to outlast
everyone else.**

The foundation

Most “mindset” content is useless. These five aren’t motivation, they’re the mental models that decide whether you make it or quit. Get these wrong and the best tools in the world won’t save you.

IN THIS PART

- | | |
|----|---|
| 01 | There’s no such thing as “your thing.” |
| 02 | The boring middle is where the money is. |
| 03 | Jumping resets your compounding to zero. |
| • | The compounding curve |
| 04 | Start before you’re ready. Ship to learn. |
| 05 | Discipline beats motivation, every time. |

01

01 **There's no such thing as "your thing."**

People waste years searching for the perfect idea or some hidden talent. It doesn't exist. The search is just a socially acceptable way to keep quitting: this wasn't it, the next one will be. The truth is almost any decent idea works if you stay long enough. The people who win aren't the ones who found their thing, they're the ones who stopped looking and went deep on one.

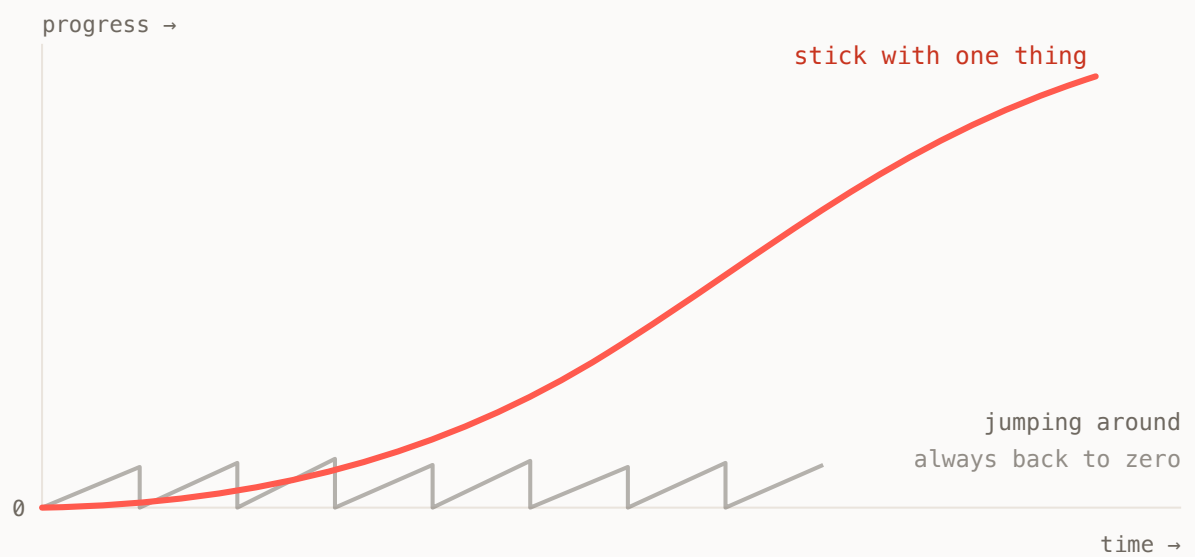
02 **The boring middle is where the money is.**

Every project is exciting for the first few months, then it gets hard and boring and stops feeling special. Most people read that as a sign they picked wrong and jump to the next shiny thing. They're wrong. That boring middle is exactly where everyone else quits, which means it's where the competition disappears. If it were fun and easy the whole way through, everyone would do it. The discomfort is the moat.

03 **Jumping resets your compounding to zero.**

This is the real cost of starting over. When you stick with one thing, your skills, your audience, your reputation and your understanding all stack on top of each other. Year three you are running on three years of compounded advantage. Every time you jump, you throw all of that away and start as a beginner again. Do that twenty times and you've got nothing but twenty fresh starts.

THE COMPOUNDING CURVE



04 **Start before you're ready. Ship to learn.**

You will never feel ready. Ready is a feeling that doesn't arrive. Waiting for the perfect plan is just hiding, a clean and productive-looking way to avoid the risk of putting something real into the world. A live, slightly broken thing teaches you more in a day than a perfect plan sat in your head for a month. Start ugly, ship fast, and let reality correct you.

05 **Discipline beats motivation, every time.**

Motivation is a feeling, and feelings don't show up on the days that matter. Discipline is just doing the thing when no one would know if you didn't. That's the whole skill, and it's the one that transfers to everything. The discipline that gets you training is the same one that ships the product and shows up on day 400 when the excitement is long gone.

**almost any decent idea works if you stay
long enough. pick one and stop looking.**

How to build with AI

Everyone's building with AI now, so I'll skip the obvious. This is how I actually ship real products solo, one person doing what used to take a team. The tools change every month. The workflow underneath doesn't.

IN THIS PART

- | | |
|----|---|
| 01 | Get brutally clear before you touch anything. |
| 02 | Make it write the plan first. Approve the plan before any code. |
| 03 | Build the smallest version that proves it's useful. |
| 04 | Never let it do anything you can't undo. |
| 05 | Read every change. Lean on tests. |
| 06 | Decide what NOT to build. |

02

The shift: your job changed.

The code stopped being the hard part. AI writes it faster than you ever could. Your job now is to be the architect: to decide what gets built, how it fits together, and what's actually good. AI is a brilliant builder with zero judgement about what to build. The bottleneck moved from your hands to your judgement, and that's the whole game now.

01 Get brutally clear before you touch anything.

Most bad output isn't a bad tool, it's a vague ask. Before any code, write down exactly what the thing does and who it's for, in plain language. The clearer you are, the better everything downstream gets. This one habit fixes most of the "the AI isn't doing what I want" problem.

02 Make it write the plan first. Approve the plan before any code.

Don't let it dive straight into building. Have it lay out the approach first, read it, and approve it. Catching a bad approach in a paragraph takes a second. Catching it after it's written 400 lines takes an afternoon. This is the single highest-leverage habit I have.

03 Build the smallest version that proves it's useful.

Not the whole app, the one piece that shows the core idea works. Everything else is a distraction until that part is solid. Ship that, then build outward from something real instead of guessing.

04

Never let it do anything you can't undo.

This is the rule that saves you. AI can write code, draft whole features and suggest changes, all of that is reversible. But anything irreversible, merging, deleting, pushing to production, touching live data, you do yourself, deliberately, every time. One confident wrong move on autopilot and you're cleaning up for a week.

THE RULE THAT SAVES YOU

05 Read every change. Lean on tests.

The trap with AI is how confidently wrong it can be. It'll write something that looks perfect and quietly break something else. Read every change before it goes in, you can't outsource understanding your own project. And lean on tests hard, they're how you catch it breaking the things you weren't even looking at.

06 Decide what NOT to build.

The weird downside of AI is that it makes adding things so easy you drown in features nobody asked for. The discipline isn't building faster anymore, it's knowing what to leave out. Every feature you skip is time you didn't waste. Ruthless focus is the entire advantage of being solo.

**ai is a brilliant builder with zero judgement
about what to build. that part is still your
job.**

The toolkit

These are the tools I actually use to build and run everything, not a list I copied off someone. Start with one in each category. You don't need all of them, you need the few that get you moving. Most have free tiers.

IN THIS PART

01 Build & ship

02 Sites

03 Productivity

04 Growth

05 Health

03

BUILD & SHIP

Claude

Cursor

Next.js

Vercel

Neon

Clerk

Stripe

Swift

SITES

Framer

Webflow

Carrd

PRODUCTIVITY

TaskBolt

Obsidian

Notion

GROWTH

X

Tweet Hunter

Typefully

HEALTH

LOKT

Whoop

Oura

Apple Watch

Building & shipping

Claude / Claude Code. My main building tool. Writes the code, drafts features and does the heavy lifting while I architect and review. If you take one thing from this guide, it's learning to build with an AI like this.

Cursor. An AI-native code editor. Great if you want to stay closer to the code while the AI helps.

Next.js. The web framework I build most of my apps on. Fast, flexible, with a huge community behind it.

Vercel. Where I deploy. Push your code and it's live in seconds, and it scales itself.

Neon. Serverless Postgres database. Generous free tier and a clean split between your test and live data.

Clerk. Drop-in accounts, sign-up and login, so you're not building auth from scratch.

Stripe. Payments. The standard for taking money online, and it just works.

Swift / SwiftUI. What I use to build native iPhone apps. If you're building for iOS, this is the path.

No-code & sites (if you're not coding yet)

Framer. Design and ship a real website with no code. Fast and genuinely good-looking.

Webflow. More powerful with a steeper learning curve, but total design control.

Carrd. Dead simple one-page sites. Perfect for a landing page or waitlist in an afternoon.

Productivity & systems

Obsidian. My second brain. Every idea, note and plan lives here in plain text I actually own. Build a system for your thinking and everything else gets easier.

TaskBolt. An AI productivity tool I'm building to turn the mess in your head into work that actually gets done.

Notion. All-in-one docs, wikis and planning if you prefer something more visual.

Growth & audience

X (Twitter). The best place to build an audience as a builder, full stop. Post what you're learning, in public.

Tweet Hunter / Typefully. Schedule, write and study what works, so posting every day is actually sustainable.

Your own face on camera. Underrated. A phone and consistency beats a studio every time.

Health & energy

LOKT. A body-recomposition app I'm building around one daily ritual that actually makes the habit stick.

A wearable (Whoop / Oura / Apple Watch). You can't improve what you don't measure. Sleep and recovery data changes your behaviour fast.

Whatever gets you to the gym. The specific app matters less than the streak. Pick one and keep it going.

**you dont need all the tools. you need the
few that get you moving, and the discipline
to actually use them.**

The body

You can have the best tools and the sharpest plan and still get nowhere running on no sleep and junk. Your work is downstream of your energy. This isn't a fitness program, it's the few basics that actually move the needle.

IN THIS PART

- | | |
|----|--|
| 01 | Your output is downstream of your energy. |
| 02 | The basics are boring, and they're all that matters. |
| 03 | Discipline transfers. |
| 04 | Make it a system, not a goal. |

04

01 Your output is downstream of your energy.

Tired, foggy and unhealthy means bad decisions and no consistency. Sort your body and the work gets easier. This isn't separate from building, it's the foundation underneath it.

02 The basics are boring, and they're all that matters.

Sleep enough. Move every day. Train a few times a week. Eat mostly real food. Get some sunlight and walk. That's the overwhelming majority of it. Everyone wants the advanced hack, almost no one does the basics consistently.

03 Discipline transfers.

The version of you that trains when you don't feel like it is the same version that ships when you don't feel like it. Health is where you practise the discipline that runs everything else.

04 Make it a system, not a goal.

"Get fit" is a goal you'll abandon. A daily, non-negotiable ritual is a system that runs on autopilot. Lower the bar so you can't fail, then never miss. Showing up beats intensity.

**the version of you that trains when you
dont feel like it is the same one that ships
when you dont feel like it.**

Your first 30 days

Reading this changes nothing on its own. Here’s how to actually start, this week. The goal of month one isn’t success, it’s momentum and proof to yourself that you’ll follow through.

IN THIS PART

Week 1	Pick and set up.
Week 2	Build the smallest thing.
Week 3	Get it in front of 10 real people.
Week 4	Fix the one thing that matters, and start posting.
Daily	Every day from now on

05

WEEK 1**Pick and set up.**

Choose one idea. Not the perfect one, a decent one you'll commit to. Write down in plain language what it does and who it's for. Set up your few tools: one way to build, one place to put it live, one way to take payment or collect emails. Don't over-prepare. One direction, locked.

WEEK 2**Build the smallest thing.**

Build only the one piece that proves the core idea works. Make it ugly. Get it live and in front of yourself by the end of the week. Shipping something rough beats planning something perfect.

WEEK 3**Get it in front of 10 real people.**

Not friends being nice. Ten people who'd actually use it. Watch what confuses them, listen to what they ask for, ignore the compliments. Real feedback is worth more than another week building in the dark.

WEEK 4**Fix the one thing that matters, and start posting.**

Fix the single biggest problem the feedback surfaced. Then start posting your journey: what you're building, what you learned, what broke. You don't need an audience to start, you build one by showing up. This is day one of the next 365.

Then, every day from now on

- **Build something, even if it's tiny.**
- **Train or move your body.**

- Post one real thing about what you're doing.

**Do that for a year and you'll be
unrecognisable.**

**the goal of month one isn't success. it's
proof to yourself that you actually follow
through.**

ONE LAST THING

This is just the start

That's everything I've got so far. None of it is complicated, and that's the point. The people who make it aren't smarter or luckier, they just pick something and outlast everyone else.

I'm still in it myself, building solo, figuring it out as I go. I'll keep sharing everything I learn along the way: the tools, the wins, and the things that blow up in my face. This guide is just the start of that.

If it helped, come find me. I post the journey every day, and there's a lot more coming.

Now close this and go build something.

Reuben Dorje · [@reubendorje](#) · build something.

More free material, and every new drop:

[reubendorje.com](#) · [@reubendorje](#)